

THE SP'S GUJARAT STRONGMAN Kutiyana MLA Kandhal Jadeja

TUSHAR TANKARIYA

GUJARAT

SAMAJWADI'S ASSET AND CHIEF LIABILITY

By Jumana Shah

mandate. He, however, soon shifted to the BJP and the SP could do little to establish its presence in the state.

That seems to be changing now. In the December 2022 state election, it contested 18 out of 182 seats. The lone seat of Kutiyana meant it finished fourth, after the BJP, Congress and AAP. Its 0.29 per cent vote share put it in fifth spot, behind even the BSP, which maintains a presence in Dalit-dominated seats, but it was clearly a fresh start.

In the local body elections that concluded in mid-February, the SP fielded 85 candidates, of which 43 won. Of these, six seats were won in tribal-dominated Chhota Udepur municipality, and three in central Gujarat's Kheda municipality. The BJP won 1,608 of the total 2,171 seats, 62 of the 68 municipalities, and all three taluka panchayats. The big loser was the Congress, whose tally shrunk from 15 municipalities to one. AAP claimed to have finished second in 250 seats, and the SP said it finished second in 200 seats. The reason the latter has found steady resonance in Gujarat, which has been dominated by bipolar contests, is anti-incumbency. Amit Dholakia, head of the department of Political Science at the MS University, Baroda, says after nearly three decades in power, there is a natural restlessness among voters even though the BJP remains strong. "The Congress is still unable to emerge as a viable alternative. Non-BJP and non-Congress parties are finding some resonance," he says.

WHO IS KANDHAL JADEJA?

- **Kandhal Jadeja's win from Kutiyana, though the SP's lone success in the 2022 Gujarat election, marked its return in the state after 2.5 decades**
- **He's the son and heir of 'Godmother' Santokben Jadeja, who allegedly lorded over illegal mining and transport businesses in the '80s and '90s**
- **Held Kutiyana for 10 years since 2012 on an NCP ticket, till the party denied him one in 2022 for cross-voting for the BJP in the Rajya Sabha polls, against its mandate**

Vadodara-based Devendra Upadhyay, who was appointed Gujarat SP president in 2022, is upbeat about his party's future in Gujarat. "We are not restricted to Porbandar, but are working to mark our presence across the state," he says. "The SP will seriously contest the municipal corporation and gram sabha polls in 2026 and field candidates in the 2027 assembly polls. We do not 'recruit' workers, we attract volunteers who are convinced about our socialist ideology, with its focus on PDA (Pichhda, Dalit and Alpasankhyak)." Upadhyay, in fact, reveals that the party's state headquarters will soon be shifting from Vadodara to Ahmedabad.

Lucknow-based SP spokesperson Ameeque Jamei, however, indicates that the Congress will lead the polls in 2027 given the INDIA bloc's philosophy of letting the dominant regional player lead in a region. Gujarat spokesperson S.K. Dubey has a different view, though. "We stepped back in Haryana and Madhya Pradesh," he says, "but the Congress disappointed. Though an alliance is imminent, it does not mean we will not tap into voters disillusioned by the Congress and the BJP."

What of Kandhal? The face of the SP in Gujarat by default and the party's greatest strength in the state, could he also become their foremost challenge? Upadhyay says Kandhal has assured them that he will help spread the party's presence beyond Porbandar, but attracting local leaders who remain loyal to the party has always been a difficult proposition. ■